

■ By Swagata Sen

Desperate times call for desperate measures. And when the biggest hit of a film industry, made on a Rs 1.8 crore-budget, rakes in Rs 3 crore in all, you know you cannot survive without innovation. Here is the new-age Bengali filmmaker for you. He realises that urban audiences do not want cheap copies of Bollywood bubblegum romance, which challenge the entire Bengali ethos of being an intelligent, cultured race. He believes in making films for both film festivals and multiplexes where the bottomline remains—"give what sells". "I make films for people like me, the urban youth. I am not concerned if people in small towns don't watch my film. I'm educated, they're not. That's their problem," says 27-year-old Mainak Bhaumik, director of *Aamra* (Us), touted as Tollywood's first urban sex comedy, and one of the few films that recovered its money last year.

Aamra is a perfect example of Tollywood evolving. It has perky camera movements, racy novel-like narratives, and characters who, as a college student remarked, "speak and behave like us". Coupled with that is a tight budget, in-film advertising and a star cast which does not burn a hole in the pocket. "I made the film for Rs 15 lakh, and it ran for five weeks," says Nitesh Sharma, 36, producer of *Aamra*.

Bengali cinema, post its glorious times in 1960s and '70s, had been reduced to two kinds. One, that made cheap rip-offs of Hindi and south Indian films, and two, that comprised the likes of Goutam Ghose, Aparna Sen, Buddhadev Dasgupta and Rituparno Ghosh—who are considered thinking directors of Bengal. Ghosh probably was one of the first directors in this league to have brought in what others couldn't—the moolah. His *Unishe April* (19th April), made on a modest budget of less than Rs 30 lakh, had reigning stars Debashree Roy, Prasenjit and Aparna Sen, and a plot that focused on mindgames between a mother and a daughter. Since then, the director started focusing on expensive projects, getting in big names from Bollywood—Aishwarya Rai in *Chokher Bali* and *Raincoat* (which had Ajay Devgan as well). Abhishek Bachchan and Soha Ali

OUT OF THE WOODS

With perky camera work, racy moves and hip characters, Bengali films have come a long way from cheap remakes of Bollywood potboilers. And they are making money too.



AGNIDEB CHATTERJEE, 42

CLAIM TO FAME: *Prabhu Dao Hey Biday*.

Features four dysfunctional urban persons who, by normal social standards, would be called perverse.

BUDGET: Rs 6 lakh **VERDICT:** Not yet released

BACKGROUND: Has been directing numerous hit Bengali mega-serials for the past 20 years

MAINAK BHAUMIK, 27

CLAIM TO FAME: *Aamra*, released in 2006.

Less of action and more of conversation, the plot revolves around urban characters who meet each other and talk freely about sex.

BUDGET: Rs 15 lakh **VERDICT:** Hit

BACKGROUND: Born and brought up in New York, has edited *The Bong Connection*